measure, the Indian High Commission clamped down on issuing visas to Bangladeshi nationals except those coming for medical treatment or engaged in legitimate trade activities.

The tensions soon spilled over into sporting ties, when in January this year, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) asked Kolkata Knight Riders to release Bangladesh cricketer Mustafizur Rahman from the Indian Premier League squad shortly after they had successfully bid for him in an auction. The Yunus regime then got its own cricket board to withdraw the national team from the T20 World Cup that India is currently co-hosting. Bangladesh did not participate in Kolkata's flagship international book fair, reflecting the extent of the damage to Indo-Bangladesh relations.

THE NEW ORDER

Against this backdrop, Rahman's demeanour since his election and Modi's own outreach are widely being interpreted as an attempt to stem the slide, even if not immediately reverse it. In his first televised address to the nation, Rahman promised inclusivity and a path away from persecution. "I would like to give a message to the people of the country," he said. "Regardless of party, religion, caste, faith, whether living in the mountains or the plains, this country belongs to all of us. We want to make this country a safe land for every citizen."

Rahman has framed his policy as "Bangladesh First" and he is unlikely to adopt the overtly pro-India posture of the Awami League. The Indian establishment, on its part, appears to understand that difference. As Veena Sikri, former Indian high commissioner to Bangladesh, explains, "Rahman's Bangladesh First is complementary to Narendra Modi's Neighbourhood First, and it should result in greater synergy between the two nations."

INDIA BELIEVES RAHMAN AND THE BNP 2.0 HAVE SHED MUCH OF THE PAST AND WANT TO DO BUSINESS WITH INDIA. BUT IT WILL DEPEND ON HOW THEY REIN IN JAMAAT-E-ISLAMI, WHICH WON 68 SEATS

According to experts, India's expectations have been deliberately calibrated. But extremist and separatist elements that may be using Bangladeshi territory to carry out anti-India activities continue to be a concern. When the BNP last ruled the country from 2001-2006, there had been spurt in anti-India activity by extremist groups, with huge caches of arms being recovered. Sheikh Hasina had clamped down on northeastern insurgents, including the ULFA and the NSCN(IM), as well as on radical Islamic networks—particularly those fostered by the Jamaat-e-Islami (JeI)—which were involved in destabilising the border region.

India believes that Rahman and BNP 2.0 have now shed much of that past and are interested in doing business with India. But it is watching closely how the BNP will rein in the extremist links of the JeI, which, with its 68-seat win and 31.76 per cent vote share, has emerged as a prominent force this election; the highest number of seats it had won in the past was 18. Now, the Islamist party has won a substantial number of seats in districts that border India, which does not bode well for us. "A rise of extremist forces is not good for any of us—neither Bangladesh nor India. The rise of the Jamaat has to be checked," says Shakhawat Hossain Sayantha, general secretary of G9, a

SHEIKH HASINA

THE DIPLOMA

She once towered over Bangladesh's political landscape with near-unassailable authority. Today, Sheikh Hasina lives in political exile in New Delhi—a presence that has emerged as one of the most delicate fault lines in the recalibration of ties between the two neighbours under the newly elected government of Tarique Rahman.

Since returning as prime minister in 2009, Hasina cast herself as the guarantor of stability and secularism, working closely with New Delhi on counterterrorism, regional cooperation and the dismantling of anti-India insurgent networks operating from Bangladeshi soil. That equation unravelled after the student-led uprising in 2024 drove her out of power—turning an asset into a liability.

In Bangladesh, Hasina has come to symbolise authoritarian overreach, enforced disappearances, politicised institutions and a state many citizens felt had stopped listening. The interim administration led by Muhammad Yunus allowed legal proceedings against her to accelerate. Convicted by Bangladesh's International Crimes Tribunal and sentenced to death, she is formally a fugitive in the eyes of the Bangladeshi state—even as she remains under Indian protection. This contradiction defines